

Practice Quiz: Perception — Why You See What You Expect

Part A: Multiple Choice

1. Your brain doesn't passively record the world. Instead, it: A) Ignores everything around you B) Predicts what's happening and shows you those predictions C) Only processes information when you're asleep D) Records everything perfectly like a camera

Answer: B — Your brain actively predicts what you'll see, hear, and feel, then checks those predictions against reality.

1. You see a jacket on a chair at night and think it's a person. This happens because: A) You need glasses B) Your brain made a prediction based on the shape and filled in the rest C) Jackets are dangerous D) You weren't paying attention at all

Answer: B — Your brain predicted "person-shaped thing in the dark = possible threat" and showed you that prediction.

1. The **spotlight effect** is: A) A stage lighting technique B) The feeling that everyone is watching and judging you C) A way to improve your grades D) Something that only affects adults

Answer: B — The spotlight effect makes you feel like everyone is paying attention to you, when they're actually focused on themselves.

1. Why can you read a sentence even when the words are scrambled? A) You memorized all possible sentences B) Your brain predicts what words should be and fills in the gaps C) Scrambled words are actually easier to read D) It's a trick — you can't really read them

Answer: B — Your brain's model of language does most of the work, predicting words from partial information.

1. A **prediction error** is: A) A mistake your teacher makes B) When reality doesn't match what your brain expected C) A computer glitch D) Something you should ignore

Answer: B — Prediction errors happen when there's a mismatch between your prediction and what actually occurs.

1. If you already think someone doesn't like you, you'll tend to: A) See their neutral actions as negative because your prediction shapes what you perceive B) Automatically become best friends C) Stop thinking about them entirely D) Always get an accurate read on them

Answer: A — Your prediction ("they don't like me") acts as a filter, shaping how you interpret everything they do.

1. Why is the spotlight effect called a "prediction error"? A) Spotlights are unpredictable B) Your brain predicts you're the center of attention because you're focused on yourself C) It's a math problem D) Everyone really is watching you

Answer: B — Your brain mistakenly predicts that others are paying as much attention to you as you are to yourself.

1. Prediction errors are actually valuable because they: A) Make you feel bad B) Show that your brain is broken C) Help you update your mental models and learn D) Prove you should give up

Answer: C — Prediction errors are update signals that help you build a more accurate model of reality.

1. You study for a test expecting certain questions, but the actual test is totally different. This surprise is: A) Proof that studying doesn't work B) A prediction error that tells you to update your study model C) The teacher being unfair D) Something you can't learn from

Answer: B — The mismatch tells you that your model of "what this test will cover" needs updating.

1. People who handle life well are people who: A) Never get surprised B) Avoid all prediction errors C) Pay attention to prediction errors and update their models D) Ignore what's actually happening

Answer: C — Good adaptation comes from noticing when you're wrong and adjusting your understanding.

Part B: Short Answer

1. Describe a time your brain "saw" something that wasn't there (like the jacket-person example). What prediction was your brain making?
2. Think about the spotlight effect in your own life. Describe a moment when you felt like everyone was watching you. Looking back, were they really? What was your brain's prediction versus reality?
3. Give an example of a prediction error you've experienced on social media — a time when you assumed something about a post or message that turned out to be wrong.
4. How could understanding perception help you deal with a disagreement with a friend? What might each person's brain be predicting differently?
5. Describe a time when a prediction error helped you learn something important. What did your brain expect, what actually happened, and how did your model update?